

Swedish That Makes Swedes Laugh

The fun chapter. Slang, untranslatable words, hilarious expressions, and the kind of Swedish that textbooks never teach you. Use these and Swedes will either laugh, be impressed, or wonder how you possibly know them.

Untranslatable Swedish Words

Some Swedish words have no direct translation into any language. They capture uniquely Swedish concepts and feelings. Knowing these words gives you a window into how Swedes actually think.

Lagom

/LAH-gom/

Just the right amount. Not too much, not too little. The Swedish philosophy of life in one word. Everything should be lagom — your food portions, your volume, your emotions.

Fika

/FEE-kah/

Coffee break ritual. But so much more — it's social glue, a reason to slow down, and arguably the most important Swedish cultural practice.

Mysa / Mys

/MYH-sah / myhs/

To cozy up, get warm and comfortable. Like Danish 'hygge' but Swedish. 'Fredagsmys' = Friday coziness. Candles, blankets, snacks, and TV.

Orka

/OR-kah/

To have the energy or motivation for something. 'Jag orkar inte' = 'I just can't' / 'I can't even.' The ultimate expression of being too tired to deal with anything.

Hinna

/HIN-ah/

To have time for something. Swedish has a separate verb just for this concept. 'Jag hinner inte' = 'I don't have time.' Swedes use this constantly.

Jobbig / Jobbigt

/YOB-ig / YOB-igt/

Annoying, difficult, tiresome, awkward — all in one word. A jobbig person, a jobbig situation, a jobbig day. Swedes use this about 47 times daily.

Duktig

/DOOK-tig/

Capable, good, well-behaved — but deeper. Being 'duktig' means being competent AND humble about it. The highest Swedish compliment and also somehow a burden.

Gå på en smörgås

/goh poh en SMUR-gohs/

Literally 'to walk on a sandwich.' Means something went badly. 'Det gick på en smörgås' = It went wrong.

CULTURE TIP

If you can naturally use 'lagom', 'orka', and 'jobbigt' in conversation, Swedes will be genuinely shocked. These aren't tourist words — they're everyday Swedish that foreigners rarely learn. Drop a casual 'jag orkar inte' when you're tired and watch the smile appear.

Slang & Casual Swedish

What real Swedes actually say in everyday life. This is the Swedish your friends speak — not the Swedish in the classroom. Use these with people your age and you'll sound local.

Asball / Asbra / Ascoolt

/AHS-bahl / AHS-brah / AHS-koolt/

Really cool / Really great / Really cool — 'As' is a prefix meaning 'very' (from 'as' = carcass, weirdly).

Fett

/feht/

Very / Really — 'Fett bra' = really good. 'Fett coolt' = really cool. Super casual.

Gött / Gôtt

/yuht/

Nice / Good / Sweet — Very casual, very common. 'Gött mos' = all good / sweet.

Skitbra

/SHEET-brah/

Really great — Literally 'sh*t-good.' Swedes add 'skit-' to intensify everything. Skitsnyggt (really good-looking), skitroligt (really funny), skitjobbigt (really annoying).

Najs

/nais/

Nice — Borrowed from English but fully Swedified. Used constantly.

Typ

/tyhp/

Like / Kind of / Sort of — Swedish filler word. 'Det var typ jättebra' = It was like really good.

Ba / Bara

/bah / BAH-rah/

Just / Like — Another filler. 'Jag ba, okej' = I was just like, okay.

Sådär

/soh-DAIR/

So-so / Meh / Okay-ish — When something is neither good nor bad.

Palansen / Pallansen

/pah-LAN-sen/

Can't be bothered — 'Jag pallar inte' = I can't be bothered. Similar to 'orka' but lazier.

Läpp

/lehp/

Boring — 'Den filmen var så läpp' = That movie was so boring.

CULTURE TIP

The 'skit-' prefix is incredibly versatile. You can attach it to almost any adjective: skitfint (really nice), skitdyrt (really expensive), skitkallt (really cold), skitsvårt (really hard), skittråkigt (really boring). It's casual and slightly vulgar but used by everyone. Even your Swedish boss probably says it.

Funny Swedish Expressions

Swedish has some wonderfully bizarre expressions. Use one of these in conversation and Swedes will be genuinely impressed — and probably ask how you even know them.

Det är ingen ko på isen

/deh air ING-en koo poh EE-sen/

There's no cow on the ice — Meaning: there's no need to worry. Everything is fine. The full version: 'det är ingen ko på isen så länge rumpan är i land' (as long as the butt is on land).

Att glida in på en räkmacka

/aht GLEE-dah in poh en REHK-MAH-kah/

To slide in on a shrimp sandwich — Someone who gets things without effort. Born with advantages. A very Swedish way to describe privilege.

Smaken är som baken — delad

/SMAH-ken air som BAH-ken – DEH-lahd/

Taste is like the butt — divided. Everyone has different taste. The Swedish way of saying 'to each their own' — but funnier.

Nu har du satt din sista potatis!

/noo har doo saht din SIS-tah poh-TAH-tis/

Now you've planted your last potato! — You've crossed the line. You've gone too far. Often said jokingly but can be serious.

Att ha en räv bakom örat

/aht hah en reh-v bah-KOM UH-rat/

To have a fox behind your ear — To be sneaky or cunning. Someone who's cleverer than they let on.

Det är inte hela världen

/deh air IN-teh HEH-lah VEHR-den/

It's not the whole world — It's not that bad. Swedish understatement at its finest.

Lägga lök på laxen

/LEG-ah luhk poh LAK-sen/

To put onion on the salmon — To make a bad situation worse. Adding insult to injury.

Kärt barn har många namn

/shehrt bahrn har MONG-ah nahmn/

A beloved child has many names — When something has lots of nicknames or names.

Gå som katten kring het gröt

/goh som KAH-ten kring heht gruht/

Walk like a cat around hot porridge — To beat around the bush. Avoid saying what you mean.

Ta det med en nypa salt

/tah deh med en NYH-pah sahl't/

Take it with a pinch of salt — Same as in English! Not all expressions are weird.

CULTURE TIP

Each of these expressions is a potential social media video. Your audience already loves Swedish quirks — imagine a video explaining 'sliding in on a shrimp sandwich' or 'planting your last potato.' These expressions are pure content gold because they're funny, visual, and uniquely Swedish.

False Friends — Words That Trick You

Words that look or sound like English (or Spanish) but mean something completely different. These cause the best misunderstandings and the funniest stories.

Gift

/yift/

Means BOTH 'married' AND 'poison.' Make of that what you will. Swedes find this hilarious.

Bra

/brah/

Means 'good' — not the underwear. 'Bra jobbat!' = Good job! Try not to laugh.

Kiss

/kiss/

Means 'pee.' Not a sign of affection. 'Jag behöver kissa' = I need to pee.

Fart

/fahrt/

Means 'speed.' 'Infart' = entrance (for cars). 'Utfart' = exit. 'Full fart' = full speed.

Slut

/sloo/

Means 'end' or 'finished.' 'Slutstation' = final stop. 'Slut på' = out of. You'll see 'SLUT' on signs everywhere. It's fine.

Kock

/kohk/

Means 'chef' / 'cook.' A kock works in a kitchen. That's it.

Puss

/poos/

Means 'kiss.' 'Puss och kram' = kisses and hugs. A sweet way to end a message.

Rolig

/ROH-lig/

Means 'funny' — not 'angry' like in some languages. 'Det var roligt!' = That was funny!

Semester

/seh-MES-ter/

Means 'vacation' — not a school term. 'Jag är på semester' = I'm on vacation.

Ful

/fool/

Means 'ugly' — not 'full.' 'Fult väder' = ugly weather. A common word.

CULTURE TIP

The sign 'SLUTSTATION' at the last metro stop, the highway sign 'INFART' and 'UTFART', and a store with a sign saying 'SLUT PÅ ALLT' (out of everything) — these are photos every tourist takes and posts online. Now you know what they really mean.

Sounds & Micro-Expressions

Swedish has sounds and tiny expressions that carry huge meaning. These aren't words exactly — they're sounds Swedes make that convey entire thoughts.

The inhaled 'Ja'

/sharp intake of breath + yah/

An enthusiastic yes made by breathing IN while saying 'ja.' Uniquely Scandinavian. Once you hear it, you can't unhear it.

Oj!

/oy/

Oh! / Oops! — Surprise or mild shock. 'Oj, förlåt!' = Oops, sorry!

Usch!

/oosh/

Ew / Yuck — Disgust. 'Usch, vad kallt!' = Ugh, how cold!

Fy!

/fyh/

Yuck / Shame — Stronger than usch. 'Fy fan!' = mild swear expressing disgust.

Hörru

/HUR-roo/

Hey / Listen — Short for 'hör du' (hear you). Casual way to get attention.

Nä men!

/neh men/

Oh come on! / Well I never! — Surprise combined with disbelief.

Jadå

/yah-DOH/

Oh yes / Sure thing — Emphatic yes with a slight wave of reassurance.

Nädå

/neh-DOH/

Oh no / Not at all — Emphatic no. Reassuring denial.

CULTURE TIP

Master the inhaled 'ja' and you've unlocked a Swedish superpower. Practice it: breathe IN sharply while making a quiet 'ja' sound. It means enthusiastic agreement. Use it in conversation and Swedes will genuinely think you've been in Sweden for years.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Final chapter: Chapter 12 — Quick Reference Cheat Sheets

Everything you need at a glance. Screenshot these pages and keep them in your pocket.